destroyed rapidly for human occupancy. Loss of habitat results in annihilation of plants, microorganisms and forcing out animals from their habitats.

Where are the Sparrows?

Common Sparrows are going extinct because of mindless urbanization. They are losing not just their natural habitats but also the essential human touch they need and thrive upon. The population of sparrows is dwindling due to the use of packed food, insecticides in farming and changing lifestyles, and match box-styled architecture resulting in an inadequate availability of food and shelter for the birds. Unlike pigeons that can make nests on ledges, sparrows need cavities to build their nests.

Habitat fragmentation

Habitat fragmentation is the process where a large, continuous area of habitat is both, reduced in area and divided into two or more fragments. Fragmentation of habitats like forest land into crop lands, orchard lands, plantations, urban areas, industrial estates, transport and transit systems has resulted in the destruction of complex interactions amongst species, (food chain and webs) destruction of species in the cleared regions, annihilation of species restricted to these habitats (endemic) and decreased biodiversity in the habitat fragments. Animals requiring large territories such as mammals and birds are severely affected. The elephant corridors and migratory routes are highly vulnerable. The dwindling of many well-known birds (sparrows) and animals can be attributed to this.

Over exploitation:

We depend on nature for our basic needs such as food and shelter. However, when the need becomes greed, it leads to over exploitation of natural resources. Excessive exploitation of a species, reduces the size of its population to such a level that it becomes vulnerable to extinction. Dodo, passenger pigeon and Steller's sea cow have become extinct in the last 200-300 years due to over exploitation by humans. Overfishing due to population pressure leads to many marine fish (populations) declining around the world.

Exotic species invasion:

Exotic species (non-native; alien) are organisms often introduced unintentionally or deliberately for commercial purpose, as biological control agents and other uses. They often become invasive and drive away the local species and is considered as the second major cause for extinction of species. Exotic species have proved harmful to both aquatic and terrestrial ecosystems.

Tilapia fish (Jilabi kendai) (*Oreochromis mosambicus*) introduced from east coast of South Africa in 1952 for its high productivity into Kerala's inland waters, became invasive, due to which the native species such as *Puntius dubius* and *Labeo kontius* face local extinction. The illegal introduction of the African catfish *Clarias gariepinus* for aquaculture purposes is posing a threat to the indigenous cat fishes in our rivers.

The introduction of the Nile Perch, a predatory fish into Lake Victoria in East Africa led to the extinction of an ecologically unique assemblage of more than 200 nature species of cichlid fish in the lake.

Global Climate changes

Industrialization is a major contributor to climate change and a major threat to biodiversity. Energy drives our industries, which is provided by burning of fossil fuels.

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